Personalized Career Assessment

SAMPLE

Sample report · prepared by Raffi Simonian · raffi-simonian.com

Every real assessment is generated from your own Ikigai answers and includes my personal review notes by email.

Know Yourself

Your four answers point in one clear direction: you come alive at the intersection of storytelling and bringing people together. The things you love — running your organization's social media, organizing campus events, watching a post or an event land — line up almost perfectly with what you're good at: public speaking, fast and clear writing, and keeping a team calm and coordinated when plans change. That overlap is your Ikigai, and it has a name in the working world: you are a communicator-organizer, someone who turns ideas into messages and messages into rooms full of people. This is rarer than it sounds. Plenty of people can write; far fewer can write *and* run the event the writing promotes *and* stay composed when the caterer cancels an hour before doors open. The combination is your edge, and your career should be built where all three are used, not just one.

What energizes you is visible impact — an audience responding, a post traveling, an event filling up. You used the word "land" twice in your reflections, and that's telling: you don't just want to produce work, you want to watch it connect. What will likely drain you, based on your own words, is the opposite: work that is invisible, solitary, or endlessly theoretical — long stretches of analysis with no audience, no event, no story to tell, no moment where the thing you made meets the people it was made for. Treat that as a filter with the same weight as your passions. Graduates most often burn out not in jobs they hate, but in jobs that quietly starve what energizes them.

At a glance — your five strongest signals:

- You create for an audience and need to see the work land.
- Your strengths are team-shaped: speaking, coordinating, steadying others.
- You write quickly and clearly — a compounding advantage in every field.
- Your cause is specific and personal: education access for first-generation students.
- You already do the job informally — social media, events, deadlines — before anyone has paid you for it.

Your Non-Negotiables

From your answers, here are the three must-haves I'd recommend you adopt — confirm or adjust them in your own words, then use them to filter every opportunity:

- Mission-driven work. Education and career access isn't a side interest for you; it's the "world needs" quadrant of your Ikigai, and you named it in personal terms. The tradeoff to accept: mission-driven employers often pay 10–20% below market early on — you're trading salary for meaning and for faster ownership of real work.
- Collaborative culture. Your strengths are team-shaped; a role where you work alone most of the day wastes what you do best. The tradeoff: collaborative environments mean more meetings and more

compromise on creative control — your drafts will be edited by committee sometimes, and that's the price of the room.

- Learning and development. You're entering your first role; a team that teaches will compound your skills faster than a prestigious name that doesn't. The tradeoff: the best teaching environments are often smaller organizations without the brand recognition your resume might crave — choose the mentor over the logo.

Likely deal-breakers, drawn from what energizes and drains you: work with no visible audience or outcome (it starves the thing that fuels you), a culture that treats communication as an afterthought rather than the product, and roles that are all production and no people — you need the event, not just the deck.

Align With Your Values

You named the cause plainly: better access to education and career opportunity for first-generation students like you. For you, value-alignment reads as high — a 4 or 5 on the worksheet's scale — because you placed it at the center of your reflections, not the edges, and because you framed it through your own experience. When the cause is autobiographical, work that ignores it eventually feels like a costume.

Here's the encouraging part: your skills are exactly what mission-driven organizations chronically lack. Nonprofits, universities, and education companies consistently under-invest in communication talent, which means your storytelling lands harder there than it would at a consumer brand with a 40-person marketing team. At a college-access nonprofit, you might be *the* voice of the organization within two years. You don't have to choose between the work you love and the cause you care about; in this field, they hire each other. And if you ever do take a detour through a purely commercial role to build skills or savings, that's not a betrayal of your values — it's a training arc, as long as you name it that and set a return date.

Future-Proof Your Skills

Technical skills to build:

- Email and marketing platforms (Mailchimp, HubSpot) — the workhorses of nonprofit and university communication; most coordinator job postings in this space list one of them by name.
- Analytics basics (Google Analytics, social insights) — being able to say "this campaign moved enrollment by 12%" is a promotion in sentence form. The Burning Glass Institute's *14 Most in Demand Skills* puts analyzing data among the core business enablers employers want across the entire economy — not just in technical roles.
- AI-assisted content workflows — drafting, repurposing, and personalizing at scale is rapidly becoming the baseline for communication roles; the *2026 State of Skills* research from Gartner reports AI job postings up 200% while only 4% of employees actually use AI in critical-skills work. Learn the tools now and you walk into interviews ahead of the curve rather than behind it.

Transferable skills to build:

- Project management — you already coordinate; learn to run a timeline formally. PMI's *Talent Gap* research projects the world could need up to 30 million more project professionals by 2035 — coordination is not a soft skill, it's a shortage.

- Stakeholder communication — writing for donors, deans, and executives is a different muscle than writing for students. Build it deliberately by volunteering for the reports nobody wants to write.

Skills you already have to leverage: public speaking, fast clear writing, event coordination, and grace under changing plans. On your resume, state all four as outcomes, not duties — "grew chapter social following 3x," not "managed social media." Per the NACE *2026 Job Outlook*, communication and teamwork sit at the top of the attributes employers seek on new-graduate resumes; you're not stretching to claim them, you're documenting them.

Find Your Proximal Peers

The worksheet's best idea: choose role models two or three years ahead — close enough that their path is usable, not aspirational wallpaper. Three kinds of people to find:

- A communications coordinator at a college-access nonprofit. Find them through your campus career center's alumni network or the nonprofit's own "team" page. Ask: "What did your first year actually look like, day to day?" Outreach you can copy: *"Hi — I'm a graduating communication major heading toward education-access work, and your path is two steps ahead of where I'm trying to go. Could I ask you two short questions about your first year?"*
- A social media manager at a university. Find them on LinkedIn by searching your own school and nearby campuses — university communicators almost always respond to students. Ask: "What skill made the biggest difference in your first promotion?" Outreach: *"Hi — I run social for a student organization here and I'm trying to turn that into a career. Fifteen minutes of your hindsight would save me a year of guessing — could I ask about your first role?"*
- An events or programs associate at an education foundation. Find them at local chapter events and conference volunteer lists — showing up in person is itself the audition for events work. Ask: "What would you have done differently in your first six months?" Outreach: *"Hi — we met briefly at [event]. I'm graduating this spring and your role is exactly the kind of work I'm aiming for. Could I buy you a coffee and ask how you got there?"*

Send one of these this week. Proximal peers answer at rates that will surprise you — being asked is flattering, and you are precisely the person they were three years ago.

Look Ahead

Three directions fit your Ikigai; all use the same core strengths, so a first role in any of them keeps the other two open:

- Communications for education access — storyteller for a mission: communications coordinator, digital content specialist, or social media manager at a nonprofit, foundation, or university advancement office.
- Student-facing programs and events — builder of experiences: program coordinator, admissions events, or student success roles, where your event instincts become the job itself.
- Marketing in education companies — the commercial lane: marketing associate at an ed-tech or education services company, where budgets are bigger and the mission still counts.

Milestones for your two strongest directions:

Direction 1 — Communications for education access:

- Year 1: Land a coordinator-level communications role at a mission-driven organization. Own one channel end-to-end, and build a portfolio of three campaigns with measurable results — numbers, not adjectives.
- Year 2: Take over a campaign or program outright — a giving day, a recruitment push, an annual event — and present its results to leadership yourself. Visibility to decision-makers is the currency of promotion in small organizations.
- Year 3: Step up to senior coordinator or communications manager, managing an intern or freelancer, with a portfolio strong enough that the next move — bigger nonprofit, university advancement, or ed-tech — is your choice.

Direction 2 — Student-facing programs and events:

- Year 1: Join a programs or admissions events team as a coordinator. Run the logistics for one signature event and keep a written record of what you improved — attendance, cost, satisfaction.
- Year 2: Design one program element of your own — a workshop series, a mentorship pairing, a first-gen student orientation track — and get it adopted.
- Year 3: Move to program manager, owning a portfolio of events with a budget, and decide then whether your next chapter is running programs or telling their story.

Your Authentic Career Compass

"I tell stories that open doors. I'm building a career in communications for education and opportunity — work where my writing, speaking, and organizing bring real people into real rooms. I measure success by the audiences I move and the students who get access because the message reached them. I choose teams that teach me, missions I believe in, and work I can see land. My first job won't be my last — but it will point in this direction."

Next Steps

Reflection becomes direction through action:

- Revisit this report every 3–6 months — your priorities will sharpen with every application and interview, and that's the worksheet working as designed.
- Use your three non-negotiables as a filter on every offer; if a role violates them, it's probably not the right fit at any salary.
- Reach out to one proximal peer this week — the outreach messages above are ready to send.
- Rewrite your resume bullets as outcomes with numbers before your next application.

Hand-picked from the library to work alongside this report:

- NACE 2026 job outlook report (https://raffi-simonian.com/files/nace-2026-job-outlook-report.pdf) — the definitive data on what employers prioritize in new-graduate hiring this cycle.
- 14 Most in Demand Skills (https://raffi-simonian.com/files/14-most-in-demand-skills.pdf) — see how

your communication and coordination strengths map to what employers want most.

- The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates (https://www.newyorkfed.org/research/college-labor-market) — the New York Fed's live data on outcomes by major, for grounding salary expectations.
- LinkedIn Grad's Guide 2026: Starting your career in the AI era (https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/linkedin-grads-guide-2026-linkedin-news-svpqe/) — practical first-job-search tactics for this exact market.
- Apply for Micro-Internships - Parker Dewey (https://info.parkerdewey.com/student/ucla) — short paid projects that turn your skills into portfolio pieces before graduation.
- Connect The Dots (https://www.ctd.ai/) — maps the network you already have, so finding proximal peers starts warm instead of cold.

I read every assessment personally and will email you my notes — what the AI got right, what it missed, and the first move I'd make — within 48 hours. And your $50 is credited in full toward any live coaching session, so when you're ready to turn this compass into a plan, the next step is already paid for.